

# ELAHI IN GALILEAN ARAMAIC

## Did Jesus Say “Elahi, Elahi”? A Philological Study of Jesus’ Cry in Mark 15:34

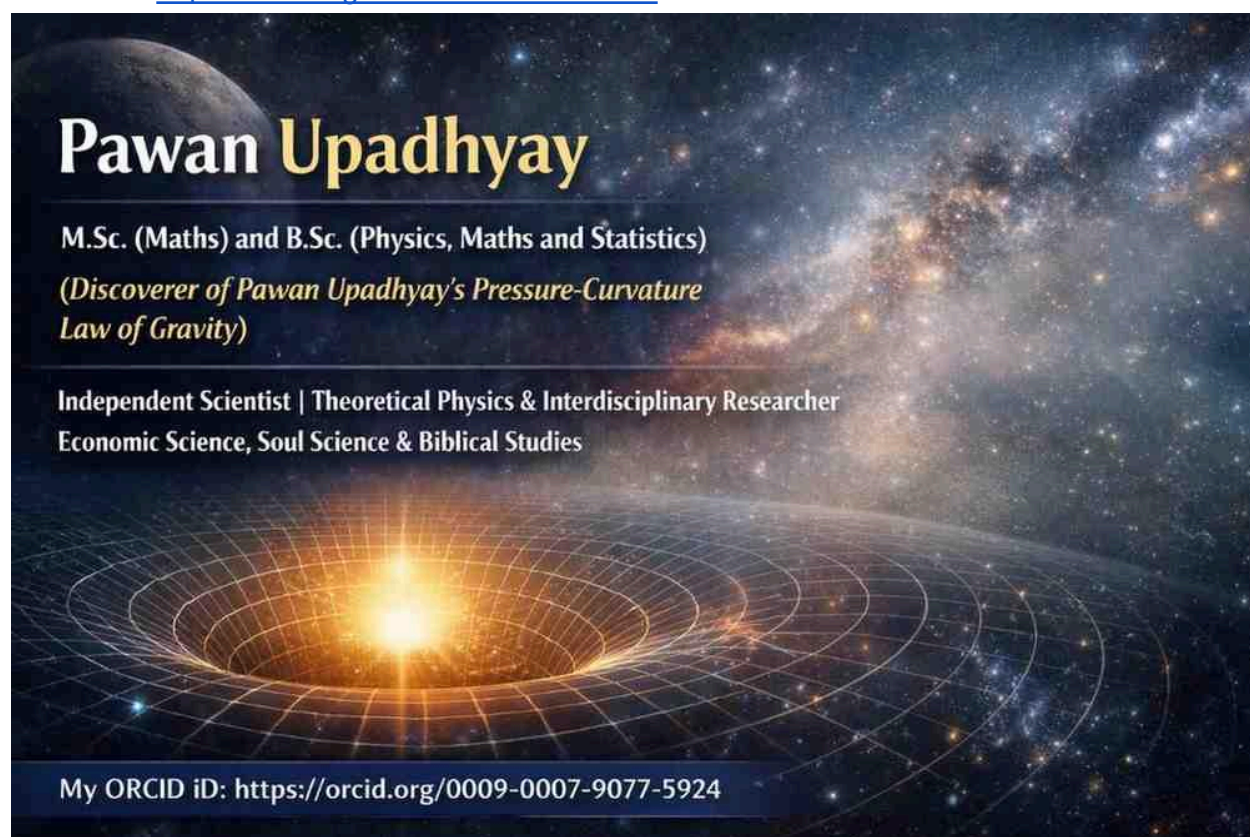
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## Abstract

The expression commonly transliterated **Elahi** and written in Syriac as ܐܠܗܝ has traditionally been understood as an Aramaic expression meaning “**my God**.” The form is especially important in discussions concerning the language spoken by Jesus Christ. Mark 15:34 preserves Jesus' cry as ʿΕλωϊ, ʿΕλωϊ (*Eloi, Eloi*), while Matthew 27:46 gives ʿΗλί, ʿΗλί (*Eli, Eli*). The Syriac Peshitta subsequently represents the expression with the form ܐܠܗܝ (*Elāhī*).

The central question of this study is whether **Elahi** can legitimately be associated with the **Galilean Aramaic** spoken by Jesus, rather than being regarded merely as a later Syriac form. The evidence indicates that the answer is substantially affirmative, with appropriate qualifications. Modern reconstructions of Galilean Aramaic represent Mark's *Eloi* as an early Galilean Aramaic form corresponding to 'elāhī / 'elāhī, "my God." The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon also attests the Aramaic lexical family 'lh, meaning "god/God," including Galilean Aramaic evidence.

Accordingly, **Elahi is not merely a Syriac invention unrelated to the language of Jesus**. It belongs to the broader Aramaic linguistic family and can be reconstructed within Galilean Aramaic. Nevertheless, because Jesus' exact first-century pronunciation cannot be recovered with absolute certainty, the most responsible conclusion is that **Elahi represents a historically plausible Galilean Aramaic form of "my God," while Mark's Greek transliteration Eloi is our direct Gospel witness to the expression.**

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# 1. Introduction

The language of Jesus has been a subject of considerable historical and linguistic investigation.

Jesus lived and taught in **Galilee**, and scholars generally recognize a form of **Palestinian Aramaic** as a principal language of his everyday speech. M. Black's classic study of the subject describes Jesus and his disciples as speakers of Palestinian Aramaic while also allowing for knowledge of other languages present in first-century Palestine.

Among the surviving Aramaic expressions attributed directly to Jesus are:

- **Talitha koum** — Mark 5:41
- **Ephphatha** — Mark 7:34
- **Abba** — Mark 14:36
- **Eloi, Eloi** — Mark 15:34

The last of these is particularly important because Mark explicitly preserves the Semitic expression and then translates it for his Greek-speaking readers.

The research question is therefore:

**Is "Elahi" a legitimate word/form of the Galilean Aramaic spoken by Jesus?**

And more specifically:

**Can Mark's "Eloi, Eloi" be reconstructed as a Galilean Aramaic form related to *Elahi*, *Elahi*?**

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## 2. Jesus and Galilean Aramaic

The historical setting must be established before examining the word itself.

Jesus was from **Galilee**, and the Aramaic of Galilee was a Western Aramaic variety. It was not identical to the later Classical Syriac language of Mesopotamia.

This distinction is important.

### **Galilean Aramaic**

The language environment of first-century Galilee.

### **Syriac**

A historically related Aramaic language that became particularly prominent in Christian literature in Mesopotamia and surrounding regions.

Therefore:

**Galilean Aramaic and Syriac are related, but they are not identical dialects.**

This distinction prevents anachronism.

However, linguistic comparison between them can still be extremely valuable because Syriac preserves many forms belonging to the same larger Aramaic linguistic system.

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## 3. The Aramaic Root ' -L-H

The word family underlying **Elahi** belongs to the Semitic root conventionally represented as:

**' -L-H**

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon lists:

**'lh / 'lh'**

as an Aramaic noun meaning:

## god, God

and identifies the word across multiple Aramaic traditions, including **Galilean Aramaic** and Syriac.

This is extremely important for the present study.

The evidence means that the lexical family is not exclusively Syriac.

The root is found across Aramaic varieties.

Thus, the argument:

“Elahi is Syriac, therefore it cannot belong to Jesus' Galilean Aramaic”

is linguistically too simplistic.

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## 4. The Basic Aramaic Word for God

A basic Aramaic form is represented as:

ʾēlāh / ʾalāh

and in the emphatic state:

ʾēlāhā / ʾalāhā

meaning:

**God / god / deity**

The same lexical family appears in several Aramaic traditions.

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon specifically identifies ʾlh / ʾlhʾ as “god, God” and records its use for the God of Israel.

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## 5. The Possessive Suffix “-i”

The most important grammatical element in **Elahi** is the final:

-i

In Galilean Aramaic, first-person singular possession is expressed with a pronominal suffix.

A reconstruction of Galilean Aramaic grammar describes the first-person singular possessive suffix as:

-i

meaning:

**my**

Thus the basic structure is:

**Elah + i**

=

**“my God.”**

Galilean Aramaic grammatical reconstructions explicitly identify the first-person singular suffix -i as the possessive marker.

Therefore:

**Elahi = Elah + i = My God**

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## 6. The Form Elahi

A reconstructed Galilean Aramaic form may be represented approximately as:

**’elāhī**

or:

**’əlāhī**

Depending upon the reconstruction system and vowel notation.

The consonantal structure corresponds approximately to:

**’-L-H-Y**

The final **-y / -ī** represents the first-person singular possessive element.

Therefore:

**’elāhī**

means:

**“My God.”**

This is not merely a theological interpretation.

It is a grammatical analysis.

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## 7. Mark 15:34

Mark preserves Jesus' cry as:

**’Ελωϊ ’Ελωϊ**

**Eloi, Eloi**

followed by:

**λεμὰ σαβαχθανί**

**lema sabachthani**

The entire expression is translated by Mark:

**“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”**

The Greek word **’Ελωϊ** is explicitly classified as an Aramaic-transliterated word meaning **“my God.”**

This provides our most important direct Gospel evidence.

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## 8. Reconstructing Mark's Eloi

A reconstruction of Galilean Aramaic gives the Markan expression approximately as:

**ʿəlahī ʿəlahī ləməh šəvāqtanī**

or in a simplified transliteration:

**Elahi, Elahi, lema shvaqtani.**

A Galilean Aramaic linguistic reconstruction specifically presents Mark 15:34 in this form:

**ʿəlahī ʿəlahī ləməh šəvāqtanī**

meaning:

**“My God, my God, why have you left me?”**

This is highly significant for the present study.

It demonstrates that **Elahi is not necessarily merely a later Syriac substitution for Mark's Eloi.**

It can be reconstructed as a form within **Galilean Aramaic itself.**

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## 9. Eloi and Elahi

The relationship can therefore be expressed:

**Galilean Aramaic reconstruction:**

**ʿElahi**

↓

Greek transliteration:

**Eloi**

The Greek alphabet does not reproduce every Aramaic vowel and consonant distinction perfectly.

Consequently, the Greek form:

**Ἐλωϊ**

should not automatically be assumed to reproduce every detail of the original pronunciation.

This is one reason why linguistic reconstruction is necessary.

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## 10. Eli in Matthew

Matthew preserves:

Ἠλί, Ἠλί

Eli, Eli

Matthew's form closely resembles the Hebrew:

אֱלִי אֱלִי

’Eli ’Eli

of Psalm 22:1.

This has led scholars to discuss whether Matthew has preserved a Hebrew-like form or has adapted the Markan form toward the Hebrew wording of the Psalm.

The textual evidence is complicated because manuscripts of Matthew exhibit variations in the transliteration of the divine name. A scholarly examination of the textual tradition notes forms including **ēli**, **ēlei**, and forms closer to **eloi**.

Therefore, Matthew's **Eli** should not by itself be used as conclusive proof that Jesus was speaking Hebrew at that moment.

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## 11. The Hebrew Psalm

Psalm 22:1 begins:

אֱלִי אֱלִי

’Eli ’Eli

“My God, my God.”

This is the Hebrew source behind the Gospel quotation.

The relationship is:

**Psalm 22**

Eli, Eli...

**Matthew**

Eli, Eli...

**Mark**

Eloi, Eloi...

The differences are linguistically interesting, but the semantic content is identical.

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## 12. Why Mark's Eloi Is Important

Mark's form is particularly valuable because Mark repeatedly preserves Aramaic expressions attributed to Jesus.

Examples include:

**Mark 5:41**

Talitha kourai

**Mark 7:34**

Ephphatha

**Mark 14:36**

Abba

**Mark 15:34**

Eloi, Eloi

Mark then translates the expressions.

This pattern makes Mark 15:34 one of the strongest pieces of New Testament evidence for the Aramaic linguistic environment of Jesus.

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## 13. Elahi Is Not Merely “Syriac”

This is the central correction to an overly narrow treatment of the word.

It is true that:

ܐܠܗܝ

is a familiar Syriac spelling of:

**“my God.”**

But it does not follow that the linguistic form itself originated only in Syriac.

The Aramaic lexical family **’lh** is much broader and is attested in Galilean Aramaic.

Furthermore, Galilean Aramaic reconstruction of Mark’s saying gives:

**’əlahí**

for the expression represented by Greek:

**Eloi.**

Therefore:

**Elahi should be understood as an Aramaic form that is also preserved in Syriac, rather than as a word that is exclusively Syriac.**

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## 14. Elahi in Galilean Aramaic vs. Syriac

A useful distinction is:

| Feature           | Galilean Aramaic  | Syriac                              |
|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Language period   | First century     | Later literary tradition            |
| Geographic center | Galilee/Palestine | Mesopotamia and surrounding regions |

|                       |                       |                |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|----------------|
| “God”                 | ’elah / related forms | ’alāhā         |
| “My God”              | reconstructed ’elāhī  | ’alāhī         |
| Gospel representation | Eloi                  | Peshitta Elahi |

The similarity is expected because the languages are historically related.

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## 15. The Peshitta Evidence

The Syriac Peshitta uses:

ܐܠܗܐ ܐܠܗܐ

**Elahi Elahi**

for the expression “My God, my God.”

This is important corroborating evidence.

But chronological caution is necessary:

**Peshitta evidence is not identical to first-century Galilean evidence.**

The Peshitta represents a Syriac textual tradition that developed after the first-century setting of Jesus.

Consequently, it should be used as:

**comparative Aramaic evidence**

rather than:

**a direct recording of Jesus' pronunciation.**

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## 16. A Stronger Historical Argument

The argument for **Elahi in Galilean Aramaic** does not need to depend solely upon the Peshitta.

It can be constructed from three levels of evidence:

## Level 1 — Aramaic Lexicon

The 'LH lexical family is genuinely Aramaic and includes Galilean evidence.

## Level 2 — Galilean Grammar

Galilean Aramaic uses a first-person singular possessive suffix -i.

## Level 3 — Mark 15:34

Mark preserves **Eloi**, which can be reconstructed in Galilean Aramaic as 'elāhī / 'əlāhī.

Together these provide a substantially stronger case than simply saying:

“The Peshitta says Elahi.”

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# 17. The Meaning of Elahi

The philological meaning is:

**Elahi**

=

**My God**

The word contains:

**Elah**

= God

and:

**-i**

= my

Therefore:

**ELAHI = MY GOD**

The phrase is personal and possessive.

It is an address to God, not merely a reference to a deity.

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## 18. “Elahi, Elahi” and Psalm 22

The reconstructed relationship is particularly striking:

**Hebrew**

**Eli, Eli**

**Galilean Aramaic reconstruction**

**Elahi, Elahi**

**Greek Mark**

**Eloi, Eloi**

**Syriac Peshitta**

**Elahi, Elahi**

All four forms communicate:

**“My God, my God.”**

This provides a linguistic bridge between the Hebrew Psalm and the Aramaic-speaking Jesus tradition.

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## 19. The Elijah Problem

Immediately following Jesus' cry, Mark reports that some bystanders thought he was calling **Elijah**.

This narrative detail is linguistically significant.

The Aramaic expression:

**Eloi**

could be misunderstood in the surrounding context as a reference to:

**Elijah**

The Gospel narrative therefore preserves not only the saying but also a possible **phonetic misunderstanding** by the listeners.

This is one reason scholars have paid particular attention to Mark's preservation of the Aramaic form. Some scholarship argues that the confusion concerning Elijah makes sense in the context of the Aramaic expression.

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## 20. Did Jesus Actually Say “Elahi”?

This question must be answered in two parts.

**Linguistically possible?**

**Yes.**

A Galilean Aramaic reconstruction of Mark's expression gives a form essentially corresponding to:

**Elahi, Elahi.**

**Historically proven beyond doubt?**

**No.**

Our surviving manuscripts do not contain an audio recording or a first-century Aramaic manuscript written directly by Jesus.

Our earliest Gospel evidence gives:

**Eloi, Eloi**

in Greek letters.

Therefore the exact phonetic form remains a reconstruction.

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## 21. The Best Academic Formulation

“Elahi (‘elāhī/’elāhī) is a historically plausible Galilean Aramaic form meaning ‘my God.’ Mark 15:34 preserves the expression as Greek Ἐλωϊ (*Eloi*), which can be reconstructed into a Galilean Aramaic form corresponding to ‘elāhī. The same lexical and grammatical structure is preserved clearly in Syriac ܐܠܗܝ (*Elāhī*). Nevertheless, because the original first-century pronunciation is reconstructed rather than directly recorded, *Elahi* should be described as a plausible reconstruction rather than an absolutely certain phonetic transcript of Jesus’ speech.”

This formulation is stronger than simply calling **Elahi** “a Syriac word.”

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## 22. Comparison of the Three Principal Forms

| Form  | Writing | Language                              | Meaning | Evidence                               |
|-------|---------|---------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------|
| Eli   | אֵלִי   | Hebrew                                | My God  | Psalms 22;<br>Matthew                  |
| Eloi  | Ἐλωϊ    | Greek<br>representation of<br>Aramaic | My God  | Mark 15:34                             |
| Elahi | ܐܠܗܝ    | Syriac / Aramaic                      | My God  | Peshitta;<br>Aramaic<br>reconstruction |

The important conclusion is:

**Eloi is the direct Gospel representation.**

**Elahi is a strong Aramaic reconstruction and Syriac attestation.**

**Eli is the Hebrew form strongly associated with Psalm 22.**

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## 23. Why “Elahi” Is Significant

The word is important because it provides a linguistic connection between:

**Jesus' Galilean Aramaic**

and:

**the Syriac Christian tradition.**

It also demonstrates that the word for God in Jesus' linguistic environment belonged to the ancient Semitic **'-L-H** lexical family.

Thus the study of **Elahi** is not merely a study of one word.

It provides evidence for:

- Jesus' Aramaic linguistic environment
  - Galilean dialectology
  - Semitic morphology
  - Gospel transmission
  - Psalm 22
  - Syriac textual tradition
  - Greek transliteration of Aramaic speech
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## **24. Methodological Limitations**

Several limitations must be acknowledged.

### **24.1 No recording exists**

Jesus' actual voice is not preserved.

### **24.2 The Gospels were written in Greek**

Therefore, Aramaic expressions have been transmitted through another alphabet and language.

### **24.3 Galilean Aramaic evidence is limited**

The first-century Galilean corpus is considerably smaller than the later Syriac corpus.

### **24.4 Syriac is later**

The Peshitta cannot simply be projected backward into first-century Galilee.

## 24.5 Reconstruction involves scholarly judgment

Vowels in particular are more difficult to reconstruct with certainty.

These limitations do not invalidate the reconstruction; they establish the appropriate degree of confidence.

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## 25. Final Assessment

The evidence permits the following hierarchy of certainty.

### Very strong

**Elahi** means “my God” in Aramaic/Syriac.

### Very strong

The 'LH lexical family is genuinely Aramaic and includes Galilean evidence.

### Strong

Mark's Eloi represents an Aramaic expression meaning “my God.”

### Strong

Galilean Aramaic reconstruction can represent Mark's Eloi as 'elāhī / 'əlāhī.

### Probable

Jesus' spoken language at this moment was a Palestinian/Galilean variety of Aramaic.

### Not absolutely demonstrable

Jesus' exact phonetic pronunciation was precisely “Elahi.”

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## 26. Conclusion

The expression **Elahi** deserves a more nuanced treatment than simply being labeled “Syriac.”

The evidence demonstrates that the underlying lexical family 'L-H is genuinely Aramaic and occurs in Galilean Aramaic. The first-person singular possessive suffix -i provides the grammatical meaning “my.” Modern reconstructions of Galilean Aramaic render Mark 15:34's **Eloi** as approximately 'elāhī / 'elāhī, “my God.”

Therefore, **Elahi** is linguistically compatible with the language spoken by Jesus in Galilee.

The most responsible historical conclusion is:

**Jesus most likely spoke a Galilean form of Aramaic. Mark preserves his cry as “Eloi, Eloi.” When reconstructed into Galilean Aramaic, the expression can be represented as “’Elahi, ’Elahi,” meaning “My God, my God.” The Syriac Peshitta preserves essentially the same lexical form as ܐܠܗܝܐ (*Elahi*). Thus Elahi is not merely an unrelated later Syriac word; it represents a genuine Aramaic expression that can plausibly belong to the linguistic world of Jesus.**

At the same time, scholarly precision requires one final qualification:

**“Elahi” is best described as a plausible reconstruction of Jesus' Galilean Aramaic expression, not as a phonetic certainty.**

The direct Gospel evidence remains **Eloi** in Mark and **Eli** in Matthew, while **Elahi** gives us a valuable Aramaic form through both linguistic reconstruction and the later Syriac tradition.

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## Key Scholarly Sources

**Black, Matthew.** *An Aramaic Approach to the Gospels and Acts*. Cambridge University Press.

**Black, Matthew.** “The Recovery of the Language of Jesus.” *New Testament Studies*. Cambridge University Press. Black identifies Palestinian Aramaic as the principal Semitic speech of Jesus and his disciples.

**Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon (CAL).** The CAL entry for 'lh / 'lh documents the Aramaic word for “god/God” and includes Galilean Aramaic evidence.

**Kiraz, George A.** *The New Syriac Primer*.

**Nöldeke, Theodor.** *Compendious Syriac Grammar*.

**Sokoloff, Michael.** *A Dictionary of Jewish Palestinian Aramaic of the Byzantine Period*.

**Peshitta Institute / Syriac textual tradition.** Relevant for comparison with the later Syriac form ܐܠܗܝܐ.

**Galilean Aramaic reconstruction resources.** The reconstruction of Mark 15:34 as approximately 'ēlahī 'ēlahī ləməh šəvāqtani provides direct comparative evidence for the proposed Galilean form.

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#### Final Statement:

“The expression *Elahi* ('ēlāhī), meaning ‘my God,’ is not merely a later Syriac expression but belongs to the wider Aramaic lexical and grammatical system attested in Galilean Aramaic. Mark's *Eloi, Eloi* (ʿΕλωϊ ʿΕλωϊ) can plausibly be reconstructed as Galilean Aramaic 'ēlāhī 'ēlāhī, while Matthew's *Eli, Eli* reflects the Hebrew form of Psalm 22. The evidence therefore supports *Elahi* as a historically plausible representation of the Aramaic expression Jesus could have spoken, while recognizing that the exact first-century pronunciation cannot be established with absolute certainty.”

## Short Form

Elahi — 'ēlāhī — ܐܠܗܝ — “my God.”

Eloi — ʿΕλωϊ — Greek transliteration of an Aramaic “my God.”

Eli — ʿΗλί / ʿלי — Hebrew “my God.”

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#### Expanded

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# Elahi and Jesus Christ: What Did Jesus Call God in His Aramaic Language?

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The word “**Elahi**” has attracted considerable interest among Christians, Bible students, linguists, and readers interested in the historical language of Jesus Christ.

The reason is simple: Jesus lived in first-century Galilee, where **Aramaic was an important spoken language**, and one of the most famous sayings attributed to Jesus is his cry from the cross:

**“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”**

In Mark's Gospel, the cry is preserved as:

**“Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?”**

— Mark 15:34

In Syriac Aramaic, the corresponding expression is written:

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi / Elāhī**

and means:

**“My God.”**

This raises an important question:

**Was “Elahi” actually a word Jesus could have used in his Galilean Aramaic?**

The answer requires some careful distinction between **Galilean Aramaic, Syriac Aramaic, Hebrew, and the Greek manuscripts of the Gospels**. When these linguistic layers are examined together, *Elahi* becomes a fascinating window into the language and world of Jesus.

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# 1. Jesus and the Language of Galilee

Jesus was raised in **Galilee**, in northern Roman Palestine.

The linguistic environment of first-century Palestine was multilingual, but **Aramaic played a major role in everyday communication**. Jesus' teaching, conversations, and interactions would have taken place within this Semitic linguistic environment.

This is important because the New Testament was ultimately written in **Greek**, while Jesus himself frequently spoke in a Semitic language.

The Gospels preserve several expressions that are understood as Aramaic words or phrases spoken by Jesus.

For example:

- **Talitha koum** — “Little girl, get up”
- **Ephphatha** — “Be opened”
- **Abba** — “Father”
- **Eloi, Eloi** — “My God, my God”

These expressions provide important evidence that the Gospel writers remembered and preserved elements of Jesus' Aramaic speech.

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## 2. What Does “Elahi” Mean?

The word **Elahi** can be written in Syriac as:

ܐܠܗܝ

A common scholarly transliteration is:

**’Elāhī** or **’Alāhī**

The basic meaning is:

**“My God.”**

The word is related to the Aramaic noun:

ܐܠܗܐ — **Elaha**

meaning:

**“God.”**

The final **-ī** / **-ī** represents the first-person singular possessive relationship:

**“my.”**

Thus, in simplified morphological terms:

**Elaha + ī → Elahi**

**God + my → My God**

The grammatical structure is therefore very significant.

**Elahi is not simply “God.”**

It is:

**“My God.”**

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### 3. The Aramaic Root Behind Elahi

The word belongs to a very old Semitic lexical family associated with the concept of **God/deity**.

The consonantal root is conventionally represented:

**’-L-H**

This lexical family occurs in several Semitic languages.

Compare:

| Language | Form                | Meaning |
|----------|---------------------|---------|
| Hebrew   | <b>El</b>           | God     |
| Hebrew   | <b>Eloah</b>        | God     |
| Hebrew   | <b>Elohim</b>       | God     |
| Aramaic  | <b>Elah / Elaha</b> | God     |
| Syriac   | ܐܠܗܐ <b>Elaha</b>   | God     |
| Syriac   | ܐܠܗܝ <b>Elahi</b>   | My God  |

|        |             |           |
|--------|-------------|-----------|
| Arabic | <b>Ilāh</b> | Deity/God |
|--------|-------------|-----------|

|        |              |     |
|--------|--------------|-----|
| Arabic | <b>Allah</b> | God |
|--------|--------------|-----|

These forms belong to the broader Semitic linguistic world.

This does **not** mean that one can simply draw a straight line such as “Elahi became Allah.” Their historical development is more complicated. But their similarity reflects a shared Semitic linguistic heritage.

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## 4. The Most Important Question: Did Jesus Say “Elahi”?

This is where we need to be careful.

It is tempting to make a simple statement:

“Jesus said Elahi.”

But historically, that statement is stronger than the surviving evidence allows.

The Gospel of Mark gives us:

**Eloi, Eloi**

The Greek text writes:

**Ἐλωϊ, Ἐλωϊ**

Matthew gives:

**Eli, Eli**

written:

**Ἠλί, Ἠλί**

Meanwhile, the Syriac Peshitta uses:

ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi, Elahi**

Therefore, we have three important forms:

**Eli**

**Eloi**

**Elahi**

All mean:

**“My God.”**

But they come to us through different linguistic traditions.

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## 5. Mark's “Eloi”

Mark 15:34 is particularly important.

The Greek text preserves:

Ἐλωὶ Ἐλωὶ

**Eloi, Eloi**

followed by:

λεμὰ σαβαχθανί

**lema sabachthani**

Mark then translates the expression for his readers:

**“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”**

This is important because Mark appears to preserve a Semitic expression within a Greek Gospel.

The form **Eloi** is generally understood as representing an **Aramaic expression**.

Therefore, if we ask:

**“What is the strongest direct Gospel evidence for the Aramaic form Jesus used?”**

the answer is:

**Mark's “Eloi, Eloi.”**

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## 6. Why Is “Eloi” Important for “Elahi”?

The relationship between **Eloi** and **Elahi** becomes clearer when we consider the difference between languages and writing systems.

Jesus would have spoken Aramaic.

Mark wrote in Greek.

Therefore, an Aramaic expression had to be represented using **Greek letters**.

Greek could not reproduce every Aramaic sound and grammatical distinction exactly.

Consequently:

**Eloi is not necessarily a perfect phonetic transcription of the original Aramaic pronunciation.**

This is where linguistic reconstruction becomes important.

A reconstruction of Galilean Aramaic can represent the expression underlying Mark's **Eloi** approximately as:

**’elāhī / ’elāhī**

or:

**Elahi**

meaning:

**“My God.”**

Thus, *Elahi* is not simply an arbitrary replacement for *Eloi*. It belongs to the Aramaic linguistic system underlying the Gospel expression.

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## 7. Galilean Aramaic and Syriac Are Not Identical

One of the most important qualifications is the difference between **Galilean Aramaic** and **Syriac**.

Jesus lived in first-century Galilee.

The Syriac Christian literary tradition developed especially in **Mesopotamia** and surrounding regions.

Therefore:

**Jesus' Galilean Aramaic should not simply be called Classical Syriac.**

They are related Aramaic languages or traditions, but they developed in different geographical and historical settings.

This means that the Syriac spelling:

ܐܠܗܐ

cannot automatically be presented as a first-century transcript of Jesus' exact pronunciation.

However, this does not make the Syriac evidence irrelevant.

Quite the opposite.

Syriac preserves an Aramaic form that helps us understand the morphology and vocabulary of the wider Aramaic family.

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## 8. Elaha and Elahi

The distinction becomes very clear when we compare:

ܐܠܗܐ — **Elaha**

with:

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi**

The first means:

**God**

The second means:

**My God**

The final **-i** is therefore crucial.

We can visualize the structure as:

**ELAH**

↓

God

**ELAH + I**

↓

My God

This grammatical feature is one reason *Elahi* is so valuable for understanding the Aramaic expression.

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## 9. Hebrew “Eli”

Now compare *Elahi* with Hebrew.

Psalms 22:1 begins:

אֱלֹהֵי אֱלֹהֵי

**Eli, Eli**

meaning:

**“My God, my God.”**

Here the basic noun is:

אֱלֹהִים — **EI**

meaning:

**God**

and the possessive ending produces:

אֱלִי — **Eli**

“My God.”

Thus:

**Hebrew: Eli = My God**

while:

**Aramaic/Syriac: Elahi = My God**

The words are not identical, but they are closely related within the Semitic language family.

---

## 10. Matthew's “Eli”

Matthew 27:46 gives:

**“Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani?”**

This is remarkably close to the Hebrew wording of Psalm 22:

**“Eli, Eli, lamah...”**

This is probably significant for the Gospel's literary presentation.

Matthew's form strongly emphasizes the connection between Jesus' cry and **Psalm 22**.

It is therefore not necessary to conclude that Matthew's use of *Eli* means Jesus was speaking Hebrew rather than Aramaic.

The Gospel tradition could preserve a form that deliberately corresponds closely to the Hebrew Scripture.

---

## 11. Psalm 22 and the Crucifixion

Psalm 22 is central to understanding Jesus' cry.

The opening words are:

**“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”**

Jesus' cry in the Gospel narratives is almost immediately recognizable as an allusion to this Psalm.

The linguistic correspondence is:

### **Hebrew Psalm 22**

**Eli, Eli**

### **Matthew**

**Eli, Eli**

### **Mark**

**Eloi, Eloi**

### **Syriac Peshitta**

**Elahi, Elahi**

The forms differ, but the central meaning remains:

**“My God, my God.”**

---

## **12. Why Did Jesus Quote Psalm 22?**

This question moves beyond pure linguistics into biblical interpretation.

Psalm 22 begins with intense suffering:

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

But the Psalm does not end in despair.

It moves toward:

- confidence in God,
- deliverance,

- praise,
- proclamation,
- and God's ultimate victory.

Therefore, when Jesus speaks the opening words of Psalm 22, the statement can be understood within the entire Psalmic framework.

The linguistic study cannot by itself determine exactly what Jesus intended the audience to understand, but the quotation clearly places his suffering within the language of Scripture.

---

## 13. “My God” Is a Personal Address

The expression **Elahi** is particularly powerful because it does not simply say:

“God.”

It says:

**“My God.”**

The possessive element makes the expression personal.

The speaker is addressing God directly.

This is important for understanding the emotional force of the statement.

Even in the context of abandonment and suffering, the word remains:

**“My God.”**

The grammatical relationship is retained.

---

## 14. Elahi Is Not a Divine Name

Another common misunderstanding should be avoided.

**Elahi** is not the personal name of God.

It means:

**“My God.”**

Likewise:

**Elaha**

means:

**“God.”**

This differs from the Hebrew divine name:

**YHWH**

The terms can refer to the same God in biblical contexts, but they are linguistically different.

Therefore:

**Elahi is a title/description with a possessive suffix, not the Tetragrammaton.**

---

## 15. Elahi and “Allah”

The similarity between:

**Elaha** — אלה

and:

**Allah** — الله

is often noticed.

Both belong to the Semitic linguistic environment.

Arabic has:

**ilāh**

meaning:

**god/deity**

and:

**Allāh**

meaning:

**God**

Aramaic has:

**Elah / Elaha**

and Syriac:

**Alaha / Elaha**

The similarities are historically interesting and reflect relationships within Semitic languages.

However, an academically responsible article should not claim that:

“Elahi directly became Allah.”

The historical development is more complex than that.

The appropriate conclusion is:

**The words belong to related Semitic lexical traditions concerning God/deity.**

---

## 16. What Language Did Jesus Use on the Cross?

The strongest historical position is that **Aramaic played a major role in Jesus' spoken language**, and the Gospel tradition preserves Aramaic expressions attributed to him.

Mark's:

**Eloi, Eloi**

is therefore particularly important.

At the same time, Jesus lived in a multilingual Jewish environment.

He would have encountered:

- Aramaic,

- Hebrew,
- Greek,
- and other linguistic influences.

Therefore, the existence of the Hebrew-like **Eli** in Matthew does not necessarily contradict Jesus' use of Aramaic.

---

## 17. A Linguistic Family Tree

The relationship can be represented approximately like this:

### Proto-Semitic lexical heritage

↓

'-L-H

↓

### Hebrew

El / Eloah / Elohim

↓

### Aramaic

Elah / Elaha

↓

### Galilean Aramaic

reconstructed **Elahi**

↓

### Syriac

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi**

Meanwhile:

### Hebrew

**Eli**

and:

**Aramaic**

**Elahi**

are related expressions meaning:

**My God.**

This is a linguistic relationship, not necessarily a direct chronological chain.

---

## 18. Why the Word “Elahi” Matters for Christians

For Christian readers, the word has particular significance because it takes us closer to the linguistic world in which Jesus lived.

Modern Christians generally encounter Jesus through translations:

“My God, my God...”

But behind the translation are ancient Semitic expressions.

The Gospel tradition preserves:

**Eloi**

The Hebrew Psalm preserves:

**Eli**

The Syriac Christian tradition preserves:

**Elahi**

Studying these forms allows readers to see how the same biblical phrase moved across languages while retaining its central meaning.

---

## 19. The Historical Caution About Pronunciation

There is an important difference between:

**meaning**

and:

**exact pronunciation.**

We can be highly confident that:

**Elahi means “my God.”**

We can also be confident that:

**Eloi in Mark means “my God.”**

But we cannot claim with absolute certainty that Jesus pronounced every vowel exactly as modern scholars reconstruct it.

Why?

Because:

1. Jesus' voice was not recorded.
2. The original Gospel manuscripts are Greek.
3. Greek transliteration cannot perfectly reproduce Aramaic pronunciation.
4. First-century Galilean Aramaic is reconstructed from limited evidence.
5. Syriac evidence comes from a related but later linguistic tradition.

Therefore, the responsible conclusion is:

**Elahi is a historically plausible Galilean Aramaic reconstruction of “my God,” while Eloi is the direct form preserved in Mark's Greek Gospel.**

---

## 20. Three Words — One Meaning

The most useful comparison is:

## Hebrew

אֱלִי — Eli

My God

## Galilean Aramaic reconstruction

ʿElāhī — Elahi

My God

## Syriac

ܐܠܗܝ — Elahi

My God

And Mark preserves:

## Greek representation of Aramaic

Ἐλωὶ — Eloi

My God

Thus:

Eli — Eloi — Elahi

are different linguistic forms that converge on the same fundamental meaning:

**“My God.”**

---

# 21. Did Jesus Say “Elahi, Elahi”?

The best answer is:

**Possibly, and linguistically plausibly—but not demonstrably with absolute certainty.**

There is good reason to connect **Elahi** with the Aramaic expression underlying Mark's **Eloi**.

A Galilean Aramaic reconstruction can represent Mark's expression approximately as:

’Elāhī ’Elāhī

“My God, my God.”

But because the direct Gospel evidence is written in Greek, the precise pronunciation remains a reconstruction.

Thus, it is academically stronger to say:

**“Jesus’ cry preserved by Mark as Eloi can plausibly be reconstructed in Galilean Aramaic as Elahi.”**

This is more defensible than simply declaring:

“Jesus definitely said Elahi.”

---

## 22. Why the Syriac Peshitta Is Still Important

The Syriac Peshitta gives:

ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ

**Elahi, Elahi**

for the expression.

This demonstrates that the Aramaic linguistic tradition had a natural and established way to express:

**“My God, my God.”**

The Peshitta therefore provides valuable evidence for understanding the morphology and vocabulary of the expression.

But again:

**The Peshitta is not a recording of Jesus’ first-century Galilean pronunciation.**

It is a later Syriac textual witness.

---

## 23. The Strongest Evidence for Elahi

The case for **Elahi** can be built from several independent observations.

### First

The Aramaic 'LH lexical family means God/deity.

### Second

Aramaic languages use first-person possessive morphology corresponding to “my.”

### Third

Mark preserves **Eloi**, an Aramaic expression meaning “my God.”

### Fourth

Galilean Aramaic reconstruction can represent this expression approximately as 'Elāhī.

### Fifth

Syriac preserves the clearly attested form:

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi**

Thus, the evidence is cumulative.

---

## 24. A Simple Way to Understand It

If we strip away the linguistic complexity:

**Elaha**

means:

**God**

Add the possessive:

-i

and we get:

**Elahi**

meaning:

**My God**

So when a reader sees:

**Elahi, Elahi**

the basic meaning is:

**“My God, my God.”**

That is the central linguistic fact.

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## 25. Final Conclusion

The word **Elahi** provides a fascinating connection between the ancient Aramaic linguistic world and the words attributed to Jesus Christ.

Jesus lived in **Galilee**, where Aramaic was a major spoken language. Mark's Gospel preserves his cry from the cross as:

**Eloi, Eloi**

meaning:

**“My God, my God.”**

A reconstruction of the underlying Galilean Aramaic can represent this expression approximately as:

**’Elāhī, ’Elāhī**

or:

**Elahi, Elahi.**

The Syriac Peshitta preserves essentially this form:

ܐܠܗܝܐ ܐܠܗܝܐ

Thus, **Elahi is not simply an unrelated Syriac word**. It belongs to the wider Aramaic linguistic family and provides a plausible representation of how “my God” could be expressed in the Aramaic linguistic world of Jesus.

At the same time, historical honesty requires us to distinguish between **what the evidence proves** and **what scholars reconstruct**.

The Gospel evidence directly gives us:

**Eloi** in Mark.

Matthew gives:

**Eli**.

The Syriac tradition gives:

**Elahi**.

All three converge in meaning:

**“My God.”**

Therefore, the most careful conclusion is:

**Jesus most likely spoke a Galilean variety of Aramaic, and the word *Elahi* is a linguistically plausible Galilean Aramaic form meaning “my God.” Mark preserves the corresponding cry as *Eloi, Eloi*, while the Syriac Peshitta preserves *Elahi, Elahi*. Although the exact pronunciation Jesus used cannot be established with absolute certainty, *Elahi* genuinely belongs to the Aramaic linguistic world of Jesus and provides an important window into the language behind the Gospel text.**

And perhaps the most moving aspect of the word is its simplest:

**ELAHI — “MY GOD.”**

The word expresses not merely belief in God, but **personal address and relationship**.

In the moment of suffering, the cry remains:

**“My God, my God...”**

That is the linguistic heart of **Elahi**.

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## Further Reading

For deeper study, the following areas are especially valuable:

- Galilean Aramaic of the first century
- Palestinian Jewish Aramaic
- Mark 15:34 in Greek and Aramaic reconstruction
- Matthew 27:46 and Psalm 22:1
- Syriac Peshitta Mark 15:34
- The Aramaic root ' **-L-H**
- Hebrew **Eli, Eloah, Elohim, Elohai**
- Syriac **Alaha/Elaha and Elahi**
- The relationship between Aramaic **Elaha** and Arabic **Allah**
- The historical development of Aramaic dialects

## **Suggested scholarly resources**

**Matthew Black, *An Aramaic Approach to the Gospels and Acts***

**Michael Sokoloff, *A Dictionary of Jewish Palestinian Aramaic of the Byzantine Period***

**George A. Kiraz, *The New Syriac Primer***

**The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon (CAL)**

**The Syriac Peshitta textual tradition**

**Theodor Nöldeke, *Compendious Syriac Grammar***